

Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a common cybercrime in which scammers trick users into transferring money through mobile payment apps. With the rise of digital payments in India, such frauds have increased significantly.

A typical UPI fraud begins when a scammer contacts a victim via phone call, SMS, or messaging apps, pretending to be a bank official, customer support agent, or even a buyer/seller. The scammer builds trust and then sends a fake payment request or a malicious link. Step-by-step, the victim is asked to click on the link or approve a “collect request” on their UPI app, often under the false claim that they will receive money. In reality, approving the request results in money being debited from the victim’s account. Sometimes, victims are also asked to share OTPs or PINs, which further compromises their accounts.

This type of fraud mainly targets students, elderly people, and individuals who are new to digital payment systems. Lack of awareness and urgency created by scammers make victims more vulnerable.

The consequences can be severe, including financial loss, emotional stress, and loss of trust in digital platforms. In some cases, victims are unable to recover their money.

This case highlights the importance of digital awareness, verifying payment requests, and never sharing confidential information like OTPs or UPI PINs.